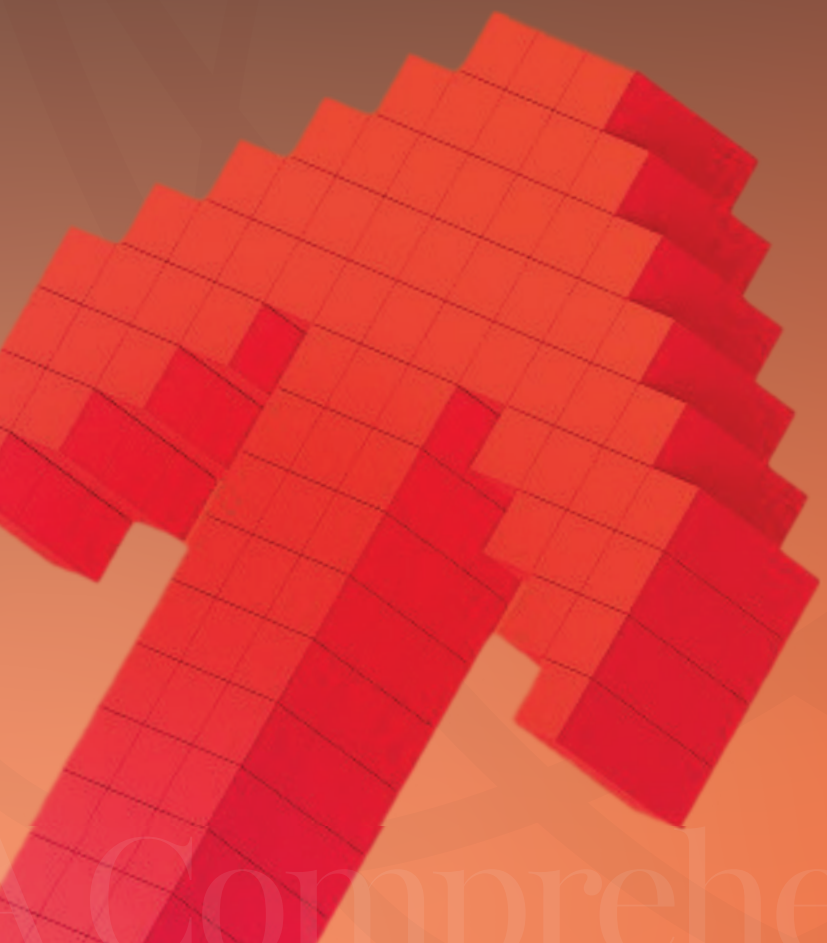
Image for Creatives

Prompt like a Pro

AI Image Generation For Beginners



Your complete guide to crafting powerful prompts for Nano Banana, Seedream & beyond.

A Comprehensive Guid

FOREWORD

Close your eyes for a moment.
Imagine you have an idea, a vivid one.
A woman walking through a sunlit city street, her cobalt blue sweatshirt catching the afternoon light, headphones on, lost in her music.
You can see it perfectly in your mind:
The way her hair moves with the breeze.
The subtle glow on her cheekbones.
The energy in her stride.
Now imagine being able to hand that vision to an AI and watch it render exactly what you see.
That is the promise of AI image generation and with the right words, it is entirely possible.
We believe creativity belongs to everyone. It's not just to those who can afford studios, expensive cameras, or teams of designers. It's not just to those with years of Photoshop experience or graphic design degrees.
Creativity belongs to the person with the idea and the one who can see something beautiful before it exists.
AI image generation is not a shortcut.
It is a new language, and like any language, it rewards those who learn to speak it well.

This guide is your foundation: your first conversation with the machine.
We will show you how to describe what you see, how to think like a visual director, and how to craft prompts that transform your imagination into images that feel alive, real, and intentional.
You do not need to be a photographer.
You do not need to know what f/2.8 means (though you will, by the end of this).
You just need to be willing to describe what you see with intention, with detail, and with a little creative courage.
This guide was built from real sessions, real prompts, and real results, refined through dozens of iterations on tools like Nano Banana and Seedream.
Every technique in here has been tested, adjusted, and proven to work.
So wherever you are in your creative journey, you're welcome.
The canvas is ready. All you need are the words.

With creative energy,

Image for Creatives™

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01
WELCOME TO AI IMAGE GENERATION

Where imagination meets instruction.

Once upon a time, creating a professional-quality image only meant booking a studio, hiring a photographer, sourcing wardrobe, and spending hours in post-production. Today, a single sentence can set all of that in motion instantly, and at little or no cost. AI image generation is the art of using words to create visuals. You type a description, and a powerful AI model interprets your words and renders an image. The better your description, the closer the result matches your vision.

WHAT IS A PROMPT?

A prompt is simply the text instruction you give to an AI image generator. It can be as short as "a woman in a blue dress" or as detailed as a full paragraph describing skin texture, lighting angles, camera lens, and fabric behavior.The difference between those two extremes is the difference between a blurry sketch and a high-resolution editorial photograph.

This guide teaches you to write the second kind.

WHY DOES THIS MATTER FOR CREATIVES?

AI image generation democratizes visual creation. It gives you the power to:

- Prototype ideas before investing in a real shoot.
- Create editorial-quality images without a budget.
- Explore visual styles, poses, and concepts rapidly.
- Build a consistent visual brand or storytelling aesthetic.
- Generate reference images for mood boards, presentations, or portfolios.

HOW AI IMAGE MODELS WORK

AI image models are trained on millions of images and their descriptions. When you type a prompt, the model looks for visual patterns that match your words. The more specific and structured your prompt, the more accurately the model can match your intent.Think of it like giving directions. "Go to the city" is vague. "Take the third left after the bridge, pass the red building, and stop at the glass tower" gets you exactly where you need to go. *Prompting works the same way.*

Takeaway:
AI image generators do not think, they pattern-match. Your job as a prompt engineer is to use language that activates the right visual patterns in the model.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN IN THIS GUIDE?

By the end of this guide, you will know how to::

1. Understand how AI image models interpret language.
2. Write prompts that produce photorealistic, editorial-quality results.
3. Use reference images to guide AI generation.
4. Optimize your prompts specifically for Nano Banana and Seedream.
5. Describe skin, lighting, fabric, poses, and expressions with precision.
6. Use negative prompting to eliminate common AI errors.
7. Iterate and refine results like a professional.

You do not need technical experience. You need curiosity, attention to detail, and the willingness to describe what you see.

02
MEET YOUR TOOLS

The platforms, models, and ecosystems you will work with.

Every creative needs to know their instruments.
In AI image generation, your instruments are the models and platforms that receive your prompts and render your images. This chapter introduces the primary tools this guide is built around, plus a broader landscape for exploration.

PRIMARY TOOLS

- **Nano Banana - Google's Creative Powerhouse**

Nano Banana is Google's AI image generation and editing model, officially powered by Gemini 2.5 Flash Image technology. It is known majorly for its exceptional prompt understanding, consistent character editing across multiple images, and seamless scene preservation. What makes Nano Banana special for beginners is its ability to understand natural language. You can describe what you want conversationally, and the model interprets intent with remarkable accuracy.

Key strengths:

- Natural language understanding - describe images conversationally.
- Consistent character editing across multiple generations.
- Multi-image blending - combine up to 5 reference images.
- Precise text rendering within images (logos, signs, labels).
- Scene preservation during edits - change one element without disrupting others.
- Integrated world knowledge from Google's Gemini AI.

Versions available: Nano Banana (standard), Nano Banana 2 / Pro (higher resolution, 4K output, enhanced consistency).

Where to access: Gemini app, Higgsfield, nano-banana.ai, Pixlr, Google AI Studio, EaseMate AI.

- **Seedream - ByteDance's Cinematic Engine**

Seedream is ByteDance's AI image generation platform, currently at version 4.5 and beyond. It is built for high-resolution, photorealistic output with a strong emphasis on cinematic aesthetics, spatial understanding, and consistent characters across complex scenes.

Seedream responds best to structured, detailed prompts written in clear natural language, complete sentences that describe subject, action, environment, style, and technical parameters. Unlike some models that benefit from keyword lists, Seedream performs best when you write the way you would describe a photograph to another person.

Key strengths:

- Cinematic lighting and aesthetic polish.
- Sharp text rendering and typography within images.
- 4K and 2K high-resolution output.
- Consistent character features across multiple generations.
- Advanced editing: add, remove, replace, modify elements.
- Reference-based generation using uploaded images.

Where to access: seedream.pro, EaseMate AI, OpenArt, BytePlus ModelArk.

PRIMARY PLATFORM

- **Higgsfield**

Higgsfield is a creative AI platform built for visual storytellers, filmmakers, and content creators. While primarily known for AI video generation, it serves as a powerful ecosystem for managing, generating, and refining AI visual content. It is the recommended platform for accessing and working with the tools covered in this guide.

Why Higgsfield stands out:

- Clean, creator-focused interface built for non-technical users.
- Supports text-to-image and image-to-video workflows.
- Built-in tools for style consistency and character control.
- Designed for content creators, not just developers.
- Active community and template library.

Access at: higgsfield.ai

THE OPTION BANK – OTHER TOOLS TO EXPLORE

As you grow in your practice, you may want to explore other platforms. Here is a brief overview of the broader landscape:

Tool	Best For	Access
Midjourney	Artistic, stylized, editorial aesthetics	midjourney.com
Adobe Firefly	Commercial-safe, brand-friendly images	firefly.adobe.com
Flux	Fast, high-quality photorealism	fal.ai / replicate
DALL•E / ChatGPT	Conversational, concept exploration	chat.openai.com
OpenArt	Multi-model access in one platform	openart.ai
EaseMate AI	Free access to Nano Banana & Seedream	easemate.ai

Beginner Tip:
Start with Nano Banana or Seedream via Higgsfield. Master one tool before exploring others. The prompting skills you build here transfer across all platforms.

03
THINKING LIKE A PROMPT ENGINEER

The mindset that separates good results from great ones.

A prompt engineer is part art director, part cinematographer, part copywriter.

Before a single word is typed, a prompt engineer has already answered several questions: What is the image for? Who is in it? How should it feel? What should the viewer's eye land on first?

This chapter introduces the five pillars of the prompt engineering mindset — the foundational way of thinking that underlies every great prompt.

THE 5 PILLARS OF PROMPT ENGINEERING

Pillar 1: Interpret Intent

Before writing a prompt, ask yourself: Why does this image exist? What is it communicating? Who will see it and how should it make them feel?

A product image communicates quality and trust. An editorial portrait communicates personality and style. A lifestyle image communicates aspiration and connection. Your prompt should be written with that purpose in mind and not just describing what you see, but why it should look that way.

Practice:
Before your next prompt, write one sentence: "This image is for _____ and it should make the viewer feel _____." Let that sentence guide every detail you add.

Pillar 2: Structure Your Prompt

Great prompts follow a consistent structure. Think of it as a visual recipe: each ingredient plays a role:

Element	What It Covers
Subject	Who or what is in the image? Age, skin tone, hair, expression, body type
Clothing & Accessories	What are they wearing? Fabric, color, texture, fit, details
Pose & Body Language	How are they positioned? What does the body communicate?
Setting / Background	Where is this? Studio, urban, natural, abstract?
Lighting	What kind of light? From where? What mood does it create?
Camera & Framing	What lens? What crop? What angle? What depth of field?
Style & Mood	Editorial? Cinematic? Raw? Dreamy? Commercial?
Technical Modifiers	Ultra-realistic, 8K, sharp focus, HDR, hyper-detailed

Pillar 3: Optimize for Control

AI models respond to specific technical language. Using the right words activates the right patterns in the model. Here are the most powerful control phrases:

- Shot on 85mm lens, f/2.8 — creates portrait-style shallow depth of field.
- Soft diffused studio lighting — even, flattering, no harsh shadows.
- Natural skin texture, visible pores — prevents over-smoothed, plastic look.
- Ultra-realistic, photorealistic, hyper-detailed — pushes quality upward.
- Editorial fashion photography, cinematic realism — sets the aesthetic tone.
- Shallow depth of field — separates subject from background.

Pillar 4: Balance Creativity with Precision

There is a tension in prompt writing between too little detail (vague results) and too much detail (confused or distorted output). The sweet spot is intentional precision: every detail you include should be there for a reason.

For Seedream, aim for 50–120 words. For Nano Banana, natural conversational language works well at any length. Avoid stacking synonyms or repeating the same idea in different words — the model reads this as noise.

Pillar 5: Iterate Effectively

No prompt is perfect on the first try. The most effective workflow is:

1. Generate a base image from your initial prompt.
2. Identify what works and what does not.
3. Add, remove, or adjust one element at a time.
4. Regenerate and compare.
5. Repeat until the image matches your vision.

Think of prompting as a conversation, not a single command.

The Prompt Engineer's Mantra:
Describe what you see. Specify how it should look. Define how it should feel. Then let the AI do the rest.

04
ANATOMY OF A PERFECT PROMPT

Breaking down every layer of a powerful image prompt — including how to use reference images.

The perfect prompt is not a single block of text. It is a layered construction.

Each layer adds depth, specificity, and control. In this chapter, we will dissect the anatomy of a complete prompt and introduce one of the most powerful techniques in AI image generation: using reference images to guide output.

THE SEVEN LAYERS OF A COMPLETE PROMPT

Layer 1: The Subject

Start with who or what the image is about. Be specific about physical characteristics that matter to your image.

Weak: "A *woman*"

Strong: "A *joyful young woman with rich dark brown skin, a shoulder-length straight bob hairstyle, and a radiant smile*"

Include: skin tone and texture, hair style and color, approximate age or energy, facial expression, and any defining features.

Layer 2: Clothing & Accessories

Clothing creates context, character, and visual interest. Describe fabric, color, fit, and behavior.

Weak: "*Wearing a blue sweatshirt*"

Strong: "*Wearing a bright cobalt blue sweatshirt with visible fabric texture and natural folds, a slim metallic bracelet on one wrist, and a black smartwatch on the other*"

Include: fabric type (cotton, denim, knit, leather), color precision, texture behavior, and accessories.

Layer 3: Pose & Body Language

Pose communicates personality and energy. Be specific about position, gesture, and what the body is doing.

Weak: "*Standing and smiling*"

Strong: "*One hand gently placed on the headphone, the other raised gracefully with relaxed fingers, as if moving to the beat: weight shifted slightly forward, conveying energy and rhythm*"

Include: hand positions, head angle, shoulder direction, weight distribution, and any movement implied.

Layer 4: Setting & Background

The background creates context without stealing focus. Describe it with the same intention as your subject.

Studio options: "*seamless neutral light gray studio backdrop,*" "*solid mustard yellow background,*" "*white-to-light-gray gradient*"

Environmental options: "*urban street with sidewalks and buildings,*" "*softly blurred indoor setting*"

Layer 5: Lighting

Lighting is the single most powerful element in photography — and in AI generation. Specify source, direction, quality, and effect.

Weak: "*Good lighting*"

Strong: "*Soft directional sunlight from the front-left, creating gentle highlights on the cheekbones, forehead, and nose bridge, with natural shadow falloff under the jaw and along the neckline*"

Key lighting terms to master: soft/diffused, directional, key light, fill light, rim light, natural daylight, studio strobe, bounce light.

Layer 6: Camera & Framing

Camera specs tell the model how to “see” the image. This layer controls crop, perspective, and depth.

Term	Effect	Best Used For
85mm lens, f/2.8	Shallow depth of field, portrait compression	Portraits, fashion
35mm wide-angle	Wider perspective, slight environmental context	Lifestyle, selfie style
50mm lens	Natural perspective, closest to human eye	Commercial, editorial
Close-up	Face and neck only	Beauty, expression shots
Medium close-up	Chest and shoulders upward	Portraits, headshots
Medium portrait	Mid-torso upward	Fashion, editorial
Full body	Head to toe	Fashion, lifestyle, movement
Low angle	Camera below eye level looking up	Power, confidence, fashion
Straight-on	Camera at eye level, direct	Neutral, editorial, commercial

Layer 7: Style & Technical Modifiers

This final layer sets the overall aesthetic and signals quality to the model.

Style options: editorial fashion photography, cinematic realism, lifestyle photography, beauty portrait, commercial advertising, street photography

Technical modifiers: ultra-realistic, hyper-detailed, high resolution, 8K, sharp focus, HDR, photorealistic skin, natural color grading

USING REFERENCE IMAGES TO GUIDE AI GENERATION

One of the most powerful techniques available in both Nano Banana and Seedream is the ability to upload a reference image alongside your text prompt. This transforms your prompt from a description into a direction and dramatically improves consistency and accuracy.

Why Reference Images Work

When you describe “a woman in a cobalt blue sweatshirt,” the AI interprets this based on its training. When you show the AI a reference image of the lighting setup, pose, or color palette you want, it has a concrete visual anchor. The result is a generated image that is closer to your actual vision, not just the AI's interpretation of your words.

How to Use Reference Images in Nano Banana

- Open Nano Banana in the Gemini app, nanobanana.io, or your preferred platform.
- Upload your reference image using the image upload button (supports JPEG, PNG, WebP up to 5MB).
- Add your text prompt describing what you want to create or modify.
- Specify what role the reference plays: “Use the lighting from this image,” “Match this pose,” “Apply this color palette.”
- Generate and review then refine iteratively.

Nano Banana Tip:

You can upload up to 5 images simultaneously in Nano Banana and ask it to blend elements from each. For example: “Use the lighting from Image 1, the outfit from Image 2, and the background from Image 3.”

How to Use Reference Images in Seedream

- Open Seedream at seedream.pro or your preferred platform.
- Upload your reference image. Seedream supports multiple image inputs.
- Write a clear prompt that references the image: “Based on the reference image, generate a portrait with [specific changes].”
- Use visual indicators if needed: describe specific regions you want changed (“change the background to mustard yellow while keeping the subject identical”).
- Iterate: Seedream's strength is in precise, instructional editing — use clear Action + Object + Attributes language.

THE REFERENCE IMAGE WORKFLOW — STEP BY STEP

Here is the exact process used to build the prompts in this guide:

1. Study the reference image for 60 seconds — absorb lighting, pose, mood, framing.
2. Write down what you observe: skin tone, lighting direction, camera angle, background, clothing details, expression.
3. Identify what you want to keep from the reference and what you want to change.
4. Build your prompt layer by layer using the seven-layer structure above.
5. Upload the reference image and paste your prompt.
6. Generate, assess, and refine.

Example Workflow:

Reference image: A woman listening to music, studio setting, soft lighting. Observations: front-facing, gray backdrop, diffused key light from front-left, relaxed pose. Intent: replicate the lighting and mood, change the outfit to cobalt blue sweatshirt. Prompt built: “A joyful young woman with rich dark brown skin... wearing a bright cobalt blue sweatshirt with visible fabric texture... lighting is soft, diffused, and frontal, replicating the even studio illumination with subtle key light from the front-left...”

05
SKIN, TEXTURE & REALISM

The difference between a plastic mannequin and a living, breathing person.

Nothing breaks the realism of an AI-generated image faster than skin that looks fake. Over-smoothed, over-lit, or over-saturated skin immediately signals “AI” to the viewer.

The good news is with the right prompting language, you can direct the model to render skin that feels human, alive, and photographic.

DESCRIBING SKIN TONE

Be specific and descriptive about skin tone, not just the color, but the quality and undertones.

Weak: “*Dark skin*”

Strong: “*Rich, deep brown skin with warm undertones, a natural healthy glow, and subtle tonal variation across the cheeks and forehead*”

Tone vocabulary to use: rich dark brown, deep ebony, warm medium brown, golden brown, warm caramel, cool-toned deep brown, rich mahogany, smooth olive, warm sandy beige.

DESCRIBING SKIN TEXTURE

Realistic skin has texture. These prompting phrases activate skin realism in both Nano Banana and Seedream:

- Natural skin texture, visible pores.
- Fine tonal variation across the skin surface.
- Subtle surface sheen where light catches.
- Realistic skin detail, not over-airbrushed.
- No beauty filter, no plastic look, no smoothing.
- Velvety smooth texture with natural highlights.
- Breathable, human-looking skin.

DESCRIBING HIGHLIGHTS & SHADOWS ON SKIN

Skin interacts with light in specific ways. Describing this interaction makes the image feel three-dimensional:

- Subtle highlights on the cheekbones, forehead, nose bridge, and chin.
- Gentle shadow under the jawline and chin for depth.
- Soft gradient of tone across the face.
- Natural glow without oiliness.
- Dewy, radiant finish without looking wet.

The Realism Rule:
If you want skin to look real, always include three things: a texture description, a highlight location, and an instruction to avoid smoothing. These three elements together dramatically reduce the "AI plastic" effect.

DESCRIBING FABRIC & MATERIAL TEXTURE

Clothing texture is as important as skin texture for overall realism. Here is how to describe common fabrics:

Fabric	How to Describe It
Knit / Sweater	Visible ribbed texture, natural folds and compression, individual fiber detail
Denim	Woven texture, slight fading, natural creasing at joints
Cotton	Soft fabric surface, subtle wrinkles, breathable drape
Leather	Subtle sheen, structured surface, slight reflections at edges
Silk / Satin	Smooth, flowing drape, bright highlights, color shift with movement
Blazer / Tweed	Structured tailoring, woven texture, sharp lapel edges
Houndstooth	Small repeating pattern clearly visible, crisp edges, professional finish

Always describe how the fabric responds to movement and gravity:

"natural folds and tension responding to movement," "fabric gathers softly at the shoulders," "drapes elegantly over the frame."

06
LIGHTING & SHADOWS

Light shapes everything. Master it, and your images come alive.

In photography — and in AI image generation, lighting is not a background element. It is the primary force that shapes mood, defines form, communicates emotion, and determines whether an image feels professional or amateur.

Learning to describe light well is one of the fastest ways to elevate your prompts.

TYPES OF LIGHTING

Lighting Type	Description	Best For
Soft / Diffused	Even, wrap-around light with no harsh shadows	Portraits, beauty, lifestyle
Directional / Side	Light from one side, creating shadow depth on the other	Drama, editorial, cinematic
Front lighting	Light facing the subject directly, minimizing shadow	Commercial, clean studio
Natural daylight	Outdoor or window light, warm and organic	Lifestyle, casual, editorial
Rim / backlight	Light from behind the subject creating an edge glow	Fashion, silhouette, dramatic
Studio strobe	Controlled, precise studio flash setup	Professional, fashion, commercial
Golden hour	Warm, low-angle sunlight near sunrise or sunset	Outdoor, warm, romantic

DESCRIBING LIGHT DIRECTION

Always specify where the light is coming from. This single detail dramatically changes how the face and body are shaped:

- Front-left — most common portrait setup, creates gentle dimensionality.
- Front-right — mirror of front-left, slightly more dramatic.
- Directly overhead — creates deep under-eye shadows, dramatic mood.
- Low angle — upward light, theatrical and unusual.
- 45-degree angle — classic Rembrandt lighting, creates triangle highlight under the eye.

DESCRIBING SHADOW BEHAVIOR

Shadows are as important as highlights. These phrases describe shadow behavior accurately:

- Natural shadow falloff along the jawline.
- Gentle shadows under the chin for depth.
- Soft shadows defining the cheekbones and nose.
- Shadow fills the neck and collarbone area naturally.
- No harsh contrast, no artificial rim lighting.
- Shadows align accurately with the sun's position.

LIGHTING PHRASES BY MOOD

Mood	Lighting Phrase
Warm & Inviting	Soft warm light with golden undertones, gentle highlights on skin
Cool & Editorial	Crisp, even studio lighting with cool white balance, clean shadows
Dramatic	High-contrast side lighting, deep shadows on one side of the face
Natural & Organic	Soft natural daylight from a window, diffused and directional
Cinematic	Motivated lighting with visible light source, atmospheric depth
Minimalist	Flat, even studio light, seamless and shadowless background

07

FRAMING & COMPOSITION

How you frame the image is as important as what is in it.

Composition is the invisible architecture of a great image. It determines where the viewer's eye goes, how much space the subject commands, and whether the image feels balanced, dynamic, or intentional.

In AI generation, you control composition through framing language, camera angle descriptions, and instructions about negative space.

FRAMING VOCABULARY

Use these terms to specify exactly how much of the subject should be visible:

Framing Term	What Is Visible	Typical Use
Extreme close-up	Eyes or single facial feature only	Beauty, emotion, detail shots
Close-up	Face and neck	Portrait, beauty, expression
Medium close-up	Chest and shoulders upward	Headshots, portraits, editorial
Medium portrait	Mid-torso upward	Fashion, editorial, commercial
Medium shot	Waist upward	Lifestyle, conversation, context
Three-quarter	Knees upward	Full outfit display, fashion
Full body	Head to toe	Fashion, movement, environment

CAMERA ANGLES

The angle of the camera changes how the subject feels in the frame:

- Straight-on (eye level) — neutral, direct, commercial. The viewer is equal to the subject.
- Slightly low angle — the subject appears confident, powerful, commanding. Great for fashion and editorial.
- High angle (looking down) — creates vulnerability or approachability. Common in lifestyle and casual portraits.
- Three-quarter angle — subject turned partially toward or away from camera. Creates dynamism and depth.
- Selfie perspective (wide, close) — 35mm lens equivalent, arm extended, slightly below eye level.

NEGATIVE SPACE

Negative space is the empty area around the subject. Using it intentionally creates balance, elegance, and breathing room in the image.

- "Comfortable headroom above the subject" — space between the top of the head and the frame edge.
- "Generous negative space on both sides" — creates an airy, editorial feeling.
- "Airy negative space above and around the subject" — emphasizes lightness and openness.
- "Centered composition with balanced negative space" — symmetry and formality.

COMPOSITIONAL RULES WORTH KNOWING

These photography principles translate directly into prompt language:

Rule of Thirds

Imagine the frame divided into a 3x3 grid. Place the subject's eyes or the key element at one of the four intersection points. **Prompt:** "*Composed using the rule of thirds, subject positioned slightly left of center.*"

Centered Symmetry

Subject placed exactly in the middle of the frame — formal, balanced, and authoritative. **Prompt:** "*Centered composition, subject perfectly balanced within the frame.*"

Leading Lines

Elements in the scene that draw the eye toward the subject. **Prompt:** "*Urban environment with converging street lines leading to the subject.*"

08

MOOD & EXPRESSION

The emotional language that makes images feel alive.

Technical precision creates quality. Mood and expression create connection.

The most technically perfect image in the world falls flat if it does not communicate something emotionally. This chapter teaches you to describe the intangible: feeling, energy, personality — in language the AI can render.

DESCRIBING FACIAL EXPRESSIONS

Be specific about what the face is doing — not just the emotion label, but the physical details:

Expression	How to Describe It
Joy / Laugh	Wide open smile showing teeth, eyes creased with genuine warmth, cheeks lifted
Calm / Serene	Soft closed-mouth smile, eyes relaxed and gently focused forward
Confidence	Direct gaze, chin slightly lifted, lips softly set, composed and assured
Surprise / Shock	Wide open eyes, eyebrows raised, mouth slightly agape at the peak of reaction
Thoughtful	Eyes slightly downward or off-camera, soft expression, contemplative stillness
Playful	Eyes bright and slightly narrowed in mischief, hint of a grin, relaxed jaw
Bliss / Eyes closed	Eyes gently closed, lips softly curved, face relaxed as if absorbed in a moment

BODY LANGUAGE VOCABULARY

Body language communicates as much as facial expression. Use these descriptors:

- Shoulders relaxed — casual, approachable, at ease.
- Chin lifted — confidence, authority, poise.
- Head tilted back — laughter, freedom, openness.
- Head slightly tilted — curiosity, warmth, engagement.
- Hands at chest — warmth, sincerity, openness.
- Arms crossed loosely — thoughtful, composed, casual confidence.
- One shoulder forward — dynamic, editorial, engaged.
- Weight shifted to one hip — relaxed, stylish, natural.

MOOD LABELS AS PROMPT ANCHORS

Mood labels are short phrases that capture the overall feeling of the image. They are powerful prompt anchors. They set the tone for every other element in your prompt.

Strong mood labels:

- Joyful ease — spontaneous warmth, genuine happiness, approachable energy.
- Calm confidence — quiet strength, serene assurance, poised presence.
- Playful energy — movement, brightness, infectious spirit.
- Heartfelt gratitude — warmth, sincerity, soft vulnerability.
- Regal poise — elevated, composed, commanding without coldness.
- Curious intrigue — engagement, openness, discovery.

Technique:
Name your image's mood before you write the prompt. Then check every element — expression, pose, lighting, color palette — against that mood. If something does not serve it, remove it.

09
NEGATIVE PROMPTING

Telling the AI what NOT to create is just as important as what to create.

AI image models have common failure modes — that is, predictable ways they go wrong.

Negative prompting is the practice of explicitly instructing the model to avoid these failures. Think of it as quality control language built directly into your prompt.

WHY NEGATIVE PROMPTING MATTERS

Without negative prompts, models tend to default to:

- Over-smoothed, plastic-looking skin with no texture.
- Distorted anatomy — extra fingers, merged limbs, unnatural proportions.
- Cartoonish or illustrated aesthetic instead of photorealism.
- Over-exposed or artificially brightened highlights.
- Watermarks, logos, or text artifacts in the image.
- Blurry, soft, or low-resolution output.

Negative prompts tell the model: “I know you tend to do this but do not.”

HOW TO WRITE A NEGATIVE PROMPT

In Nano Banana: Include negative instructions directly in your main prompt using phrases like “no harsh shadows,” “no plastic skin,” “no distortion.”

In Seedream: Add a dedicated negative prompt block at the end of your prompt, clearly labeled.

THE MASTER NEGATIVE PROMPT

This is the core negative prompt block used across all examples in this guide. Copy it as your starting point and adjust as needed:

NEGATIVE PROMPT (STANDARD)
no distortion, no plastic-looking skin, no cartoon style, no CGI look, no unrealistic anatomy, no extra limbs, no extra fingers, no merged body parts, no blur on face, no overexposure, no harsh artificial shadows, no watermark, no text artifacts, no flat textures, no over-smoothing, no beauty filter, no artificial rim lighting, no low resolution, no noise, no grain

TARGETED NEGATIVE PROMPTS BY SITUATION

Issue to Avoid	Negative Prompt Phrase
Plastic / fake skin	no plastic skin, no over-smoothing, no beauty filter, no airbrushing
Anatomy errors	no extra limbs, no merged fingers, no distorted proportions, no unrealistic anatomy
AI look / CGI	no CGI, no cartoon style, no illustrated look, no rendered appearance
Bad lighting	no harsh shadows, no overexposure, no artificial rim lighting, no flat lighting
Low quality	no low resolution, no blur, no noise, no grain, no artifacts
Unwanted elements	no watermark, no text, no logo, no background clutter
Wrong aesthetic	no vintage filter, no desaturation, no HDR overdone effect

Important Note for Nano Banana:

Nano Banana does not have a separate negative prompt field in most interfaces. Instead, weave your negative instructions into the main prompt naturally: "...skin texture is realistic and natural — no smoothing, no airbrushing, no plastic look."

10
PROMPT TEMPLATES & EXAMPLES

Real prompts. Real breakdowns. Techniques you can use today.

This chapter is the heart of the guide. Every example here was built from a real image reference in a real prompt engineering session.

Each one follows the same format: the category, a before-and-after comparison, a step-by-step breakdown of what was added and why, and the final ready-to-use prompt.

EXAMPLE 01 — FEMALE PORTRAIT

Category: Studio Portrait / Fashion Editorial

BEFORE (Weak Prompt):

> *A woman listening to music with headphones, smiling, gray background.*

AFTER (Engineered Prompt):

> *A joyful young woman with rich dark brown skin, smooth and glowing with natural highlights and subtle texture visible on her cheeks and forehead. She has a radiant smile, white teeth, and closed eyes, enjoying the rhythm of music through large matte-black over-ear headphones. Her straight, shoulder-length bob hairstyle frames her face neatly. She wears a bright cobalt blue sweatshirt with visible fabric texture and folds, a slim metallic bracelet on one wrist, and a black smartwatch on the other. One hand is gently placed on the headphone, the other raised gracefully with relaxed fingers, as if moving to the beat. The background is a seamless neutral light gray studio backdrop. Lighting is soft, diffused, and even, with subtle key light from the front and gentle fill, creating natural shadows under the chin and along the jawline. Captured in professional portrait photography style, ultra-realistic, high resolution. Shot with an 85mm prime portrait lens, aperture f/2.8, shallow depth of field.*
> NEGATIVE: *no plastic skin, no airbrushing, no extra fingers, no distortion, no watermark.*

Breakdown — What Was Added and Why:

- Skin tone with texture cues — “smooth and glowing with natural highlights and subtle texture visible” prevents plastic look.
- Expression detail — “closed eyes, enjoying the rhythm” creates believable emotional context.
- Accessory precision — bracelet on one wrist, smartwatch on the other adds realism depth.
- Gesture description — “raised gracefully with relaxed fingers, as if moving to the beat” adds life and movement.
- Lighting specifics — key light source + fill + shadow placement gives the model a complete lighting map.
- 85mm f/2.8 — activates portrait compression and shallow depth of field.

EXAMPLE 02 — MALE PORTRAIT

Category: Studio Portrait / Bold Color Editorial

BEFORE (Weak Prompt):

> *A man in a pink sweater with glasses, yellow background, smiling.*

AFTER (Engineered Prompt):

> *A joyful young man with deep brown skin, a tall flat-top haircut, and stylish transparent eyeglasses, smiling with his eyes closed in a relaxed, playful pose. He is wearing a vibrant pink knitted sweater with visible ribbed texture and natural folds. One hand rests gently near his temple as if emphasizing a thought, adorned with a silver ring, while his other arm crosses casually across his torso. The background is a bold solid mustard yellow, seamless and evenly lit, creating a striking contrast with the sweater. Lighting is soft, diffused, and frontal, with subtle natural shadows around the neckline and arms for depth. Skin texture is realistic and natural, with gentle highlights on the cheekbones, nose, and forehead. Framed as a waist-up portrait, centered composition. Captured in ultra-realistic professional studio photography, 85mm prime lens at f/2.8.* NEGATIVE: *no plastic skin, no cartoonish look, no extra fingers, no distortion, no overexposure.*

Breakdown — What Was Added and Why:

- Bold background color as design tool — mustard yellow creates intentional contrast with pink sweater.
- Hair specificity — “tall flat-top haircut” is a defining character detail.
- “Transparent eyeglasses” — material detail on accessories adds photographic realism.
- Silver ring with light reflection — micro-detail that dramatically boosts realism.
- Waist-up framing — specified explicitly to give shoulders and outfit room to breathe.

EXAMPLE 03 — EXPRESSIVE REACTION SHOT

Category: Commercial / Expressive Portrait

BEFORE (Weak Prompt):

> *Surprised man in colorful clothes, pink background.*

AFTER (Engineered Prompt):

> *Ultra-realistic portrait of a surprised man with dark brown skin, centered in the frame against a seamless solid pink background. Medium portrait framing, showing the subject from mid-torso upwards with extra space around the shoulders, straight-on angle. His expression is shocked, with wide open eyes, raised eyebrows, and mouth agape — captured at the peak of the reaction. Natural skin texture is visible with pores, fine details, and subtle tonal variations. He has a full, neatly groomed beard with visible individual hairs. He wears a bright neon green knitted beanie with detailed wool fibers, a pastel lavender t-shirt, and a purple jacket with matte fabric texture. Photographed in ultra-high resolution, cinematic editorial style, 85mm lens, shallow depth of field with razor-sharp focus on the face, HDR studio lighting, crisp color grading.* NEGATIVE: *no plastic skin, no blur on face, no overexposure, no distortion, no watermark.*

Breakdown — What Was Added and Why:

- "Captured at the peak of the reaction" — timing language that tells the model to render the height of the expression.
- Bold color palette described intentionally — neon green + lavender + pink creates deliberate visual energy.
- "Beard with visible individual hairs" — texture detail extends beyond skin to facial hair.
- "Mid-torso upwards with extra space around the shoulders" — precise framing instruction for a wider editorial shot.

EXAMPLE 04 — SELFIE / LIFESTYLE PORTRAIT

Category: Lifestyle / Casual Editorial

BEFORE (Weak Prompt):

> *Man taking a selfie, waving, white background, pink sweater.*

AFTER (Engineered Prompt):

> *A joyful young man taking a casual selfie, captured in a close-up, slightly low-angle shot. He has short coiled natural hair, smooth dark brown skin with a natural healthy glow, and is wearing round black-rimmed glasses. His expression is lively and energetic, with a wide open smile showing teeth, and bright, engaging eyes. He is dressed in a soft pastel pink knitted sweater with visible fabric texture and folds, paired with blue jeans. One arm is extended toward the camera lens, slightly blurred from perspective, while the other hand is raised mid-wave, creating a playful and dynamic framing. The background is a clean, minimal white wall that contrasts strongly with his outfit and skin tone. Lighting is soft, bright, and evenly diffused. Skin texture is hyper-realistic, showing natural pores and light reflections without artificial smoothness. Technical: Ultra-realistic, high-resolution 8K. Sharp focus on face, shallow depth of field for natural perspective blur. 35mm wide-angle lens, selfie perspective. Style: lifestyle editorial photography, cinematic realism.* NEGATIVE: *no distortion, no plastic skin, no extra fingers, no blur on face, no overexposure, no watermark.*

Breakdown — What Was Added and Why:

- 35mm lens — selfie perspective requires a wider lens than a standard portrait.
- Arm blur — “slightly blurred from perspective” is an intentional realism cue for the extended arm.
- “Short coiled natural hair” — specific hair texture that adds authenticity and representation.
- Lifestyle mood language — “playful and dynamic framing” sets the energy of the entire image.

EXAMPLE 05 — THREE POSE VARIATIONS

Category: Editorial Portrait Series / Pose Direction

One reference image can generate an entire series. Here are three distinct poses from a single subject — each with its own mood label, body language, and emotional energy.

Pose 1 — Heartfelt Gratitude

The woman stands facing slightly toward camera left with both hands placed softly over her upper chest in a gesture of warmth and sincerity. Her shoulders are relaxed, posture upright, and her head tilts gently forward with a tender, heartfelt smile that conveys genuine appreciation. Her eyes are bright and kind, engaging directly with the viewer. Balanced negative space surrounds her head and shoulders, ensuring a clean, elegant portrait composition with even, diffused lighting across her skin tone.

Pose 2 — Joyful Ease

The woman shifts slightly to a three-quarter angle, shoulders turned a bit toward camera right. One hand remains resting gently at her chest, while the other lowers to her waist in a relaxed, open position. Her head tilts back slightly as she laughs softly, eyes half-closed in natural joy. The expression feels spontaneous and effortless, capturing the warmth of genuine laughter. The light catches highlights along her cheekbones and collarbones, emphasizing her glowing complexion.

Pose 3 — Calm Confidence

She faces directly forward, posture poised and steady. Her chin lifts slightly, giving her an assured, serene expression. Both hands rest gently along her midsection, maintaining a sense of composure and self-assurance. Her lips curve into a soft, closed smile — peaceful, confident, and reflective. Her eyes meet the camera with quiet strength. The lighting remains soft and balanced to highlight depth and natural sheen. The background stays neutral and uncluttered, providing ample negative space to emphasize the subject's elegance and presence.

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ITERATING & REFINING

Your first prompt is a starting point, not a final answer.

The most common mistake beginners make is treating a prompt as a one-shot attempt.

Professional prompt engineers iterate — they generate, assess, adjust, and regenerate. Each cycle brings the image closer to the vision. This chapter teaches you how to iterate effectively and efficiently.

THE ITERATION LOOP

1. Generate your base image from your initial prompt.
2. Step back and assess objectively: what works, what does not?
3. Identify the single most important thing to fix.
4. Adjust only that element in your prompt.
5. Regenerate and compare with the previous version.
6. Repeat until satisfied.

The key discipline: change one thing at a time. Changing multiple elements simultaneously makes it impossible to know what caused the improvement.

COMMON ISSUES AND HOW TO FIX THEM

Issue	Likely Cause	Fix
Skin looks plastic	No texture language	Add: natural skin texture, visible pores, no smoothing
Wrong framing / crop	No framing specified	Add: medium portrait, waist-up, chest-level framing
Flat, dull lighting	Generic lighting description	Specify: key light direction, shadow placement, light quality
Expression not right	Too vague	Describe physical details: “eyes crinkled,” “mouth open at peak”
Fabric looks generic	No texture detail	Add: ribbed texture, visible weave, natural folds, drape behavior
Background too busy	Not described clearly	Specify: seamless, solid color, gradient, clean minimal
Wrong body proportions	No anatomy anchors	Add negative: no distorted proportions, no unrealistic anatomy
Too cartoonish	Missing realism modifiers	Add: ultra-realistic, photorealistic, editorial photography style

SCALING YOUR PROMPT UP AND DOWN

Sometimes you want a quick test. Sometimes you want maximum control. Here is how to scale the same prompt for different needs:

The Power Compact Prompt — Fast Testing

One to two sentences with the most essential details. Use when exploring concepts or testing color/mood combinations quickly.

> *Joyful young woman with deep brown skin, cobalt blue sweatshirt, over-ear headphones, gray studio backdrop. Soft studio lighting, 85mm lens, ultra-realistic editorial portrait, natural skin texture, no smoothing.*

The Cinematic Detailed Prompt — Full Control

The complete seven-layer prompt with all technical modifiers. Use when you need a specific, high-quality result with minimal variation.

The examples in Chapter 10 are all Cinematic Detailed prompts.

SAVING YOUR BEST PROMPTS

Build a personal prompt library. For every successful image, save:

- The full prompt text.
- The platform it was generated on (Nano Banana / Seedream).
- The key technique that made it work.
- A note on what you would change next time.

Over time, this library becomes your most powerful creative asset — a personalized system of language that reliably produces the images you envision.

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QUICK REFERENCE CHEAT SHEET

Everything you need, on one page.

THE FILL-IN-THE-BLANK PROMPT TEMPLATE

A [MOOD] [SUBJECT DESCRIPTION] *with* [SKIN TONE & TEXTURE], [HAIR DESCRIPTION], *and* [EXPRESSION DETAIL]. *They are wearing* [CLOTHING WITH FABRIC DETAIL], [ACCESSORIES]. [POSE & BODY LANGUAGE DESCRIPTION]. *The background is* [BACKGROUND DESCRIPTION]. *Lighting is* [LIGHTING TYPE] *from* [DIRECTION], *creating* [SHADOW/HIGHLIGHT EFFECT]. *Framed as* [FRAMING TERM], [CAMERA ANGLE], [COMPOSITION NOTE]. *Captured in* [STYLE], [RESOLUTION], [LENS] *at* [APERTURE]. NEGATIVE: *no plastic skin, no distortion, no extra fingers, no watermark, no cartoonish look.*

THE MASTER REFERENCE TABLE

Element	Go-To Options
Skin Tone	rich dark brown, deep ebony, warm medium brown, golden caramel, cool-toned deep brown, warm olive
Skin Texture	natural pores, fine tonal variation, subtle surface sheen, velvety smooth, dewy glow, no smoothing
Lighting Type	soft diffused, directional side light, front studio, natural daylight, golden hour, rim/backlight
Light Direction	front-left, front-right, 45-degree angle, directly overhead, low angle, from window right
Framing	close-up, medium close-up, medium portrait, medium shot, three-quarter, full body
Camera Angle	straight-on, slightly low angle, high angle, three-quarter turn, selfie perspective
Lens & Aperture	85mm f/2.8 (portrait), 35mm (lifestyle/selfie), 50mm f/1.8 (commercial)
Style Modifiers	editorial fashion, cinematic realism, lifestyle photography, beauty portrait, commercial advertising
Quality Modifiers	ultra-realistic, hyper-detailed, 8K, sharp focus, HDR, high resolution, photorealistic
Fabric Terms	ribbed texture, visible weave, natural folds, drapes softly, structured tailoring, matte surface
Expression Terms	radiant smile, eyes crinkled with joy, calm direct gaze, mouth agape at peak of reaction
Mood Labels	joyful ease, calm confidence, playful energy, heartfelt gratitude, regal poise, curious intrigue

WORD BANKS

Skin & Texture

natural pores — fine tonal variation — subtle surface sheen — velvety smooth — dewy radiant glow — healthy natural glow — visible skin texture — no smoothing — no airbrushing — breathable human-looking skin — realistic skin detail — soft gradient of tone

Lighting

soft diffused — directional — key light — fill light — natural shadow falloff — gentle highlights — subtle highlights on cheekbones — warm golden light — crisp studio strobe — no harsh contrast — balanced illumination — motivated light source

Camera & Framing

85mm lens — f/2.8 — f/1.8 — shallow depth of field — sharp focus on face — slight background blur — wide-angle selfie perspective — close-up — medium portrait — full body — low angle — straight-on — three-quarter angle — generous headroom — negative space

Fabric & Clothing

ribbed knit texture — visible fabric weave — natural folds — fabric tension — responds to movement — drapes elegantly — structured tailoring — matte surface — catches light at edges — fabric gathers softly — individual fiber detail

Mood & Expression

radiant smile — genuine joy — direct gaze — calm and composed — peak of the reaction — eyes half-closed in natural laughter — chin lifted — shoulders relaxed — playful wave — thoughtful stillness — quiet confidence — spontaneous energy

NEGATIVE PROMPT ESSENTIALS

no plastic skin — no over-smoothing — no airbrushing — no beauty filter — no CGI — no cartoon look — no extra fingers — no distorted anatomy — no watermark — no blur on face — no harsh shadows — no overexposure — no low resolution — no noise

You now have everything you need.

Open your platform. Write your first prompt. Iterate.